

Chapter-9

TENSES (CONCORD AND SEQUENCE)

1 Use of Tenses :

1. Present Indefinite Tense

The Present Indefinite Tense is used :

- (a) To express what is actually taking place at the present moment : as,
 - (i) I **play**.
 - (ii) The boys **sing** a song.
 - (iii) See how he **works**!
- (b) To express a habitual action, a habit or a custom ; as,
 - (i) She **reads** newspaper every day.
 - (ii) I **get up** early in the morning.
 - (iii) He **goes** for a walk every day.
- (c) To express a general truth, as,
 - (i) The earth **revolves** round the sun.
 - (ii) **Man** is mortal.
 - (iii) Sugar **is** sweet.
- (d) To narrate some past events in an exciting or a vivid manner ; as,

The plane **takes off**. Suddenly, a young man in black clothes **rushes** into the cock-pit. He **carries** a revolver in his hand. Two more youngmen and a young girl appear on the scene with hand grenades in their hands. They shout: "Nobody shall try to get up. Keep where you are."
- (e) To express a future event, which is already arranged ; *as*,
 - (i) The ship **sails** for England next week.
 - (ii) Our examination **begins** on Wednesday.
- (f) To quote authors; *as*,
 - (i) Keats **says**, "A thing of beauty is a joy for ever."
 - (ii) Pope **writes**, "A little knowledge is a dangerous thing."
- (g) In conditional sentence ; *as*,
 - (i) If I **go** to Delhi, I shall bring a camera for you.
 - (ii) If Sachin **plays** in this match, we shall win.

- (h) With a Verbs which cannot be used in the continuous form; *as*,
 - (i) She **loves** me. (*It is wrong to say ; She is loving me.*)
 - (ii) I **know** you. (not 'I am knowing you')
 - (iii) It **seems** proper.
 - (iv) Virtue **means** goodness.

2. Present Continuous Tense

This tense is used :

- (a) To express an action that is going on at the time of speaking, e.g.
 - 1. She **is knitting** socks.
 - 2. You **are deceiving** your friend.
- (b) As a substitute for the immediate future, e.g.
 - 1. My brother **is reaching** after an hour.
 - 2. She **is leaving** this place tomorrow.
 - 3. You **are proceeding** to America next month.

3. Present Perfect Tense

This tense is used :

- (a) To indicate an action which as just been over, *e.g.*
 - 1. I **have finished** my work.
 - 2. She **has drafted** the application.
- (b) To denote a past action, the results of which are still present, *e.g.*
 - 1. He **has opened** a new shop.
 - 2. She **has passed** the M.A examination.
- (c) In Adverbial clauses beginning with 'when', 'if', 'before', 'after', 'as soon as' or 'till' and when the principal verb is in Future Tense, *e.g.*
 - 1. As soon as I **have finished** this job, I shall come to see you.
 - 2. I shall ring up after I **have talked** to her.

4. Present Perfect Continuous Tense

This tense is used : (a) to denote an action that began in the past and is continuing up to the present, *e.g.*

- 1. I **has been raining** since morning.
- 2. We **have been living** in this house for two years.

(The use of the preposition '*for*' or '*since*' in a sentence of the present perfect continuous tense is essential.)

5. Past Indefinite or Simple Past Tense

This tense is used :

- (a) To express a single act of the past, *e.g.*
 - 1. He **broke** this table.
 - 2. They **were** in the garden.
 - 3. She **was** absent yesterday.
- (b) To express a habitual action or custom in the past, *e.g.*
 - 1. She **got up** at 4 a.m. every day.
 - 2. Our ancestors **were** honest and hard working.
- (c) As a substitute for the Past Continuous Tense, *e.g.*
 - 1. While they **played**, we **took** tea.
 - 2. While we **talked**, they **slept**.

6. Past Continuous Tense

This tense is used : (a) to denote an action that was going on at some time in the past, *e.g.*

- 1. They **were playing** hockey.
- 2. She **was singing** a song.

7. Past Perfect Tense

This tense is used : (a) to denote an action which had been completed before another action began in the past. It is always used in a complex sentence, *e.g.*

- 1. When I reached there, she **had finished** her work.
- 2. The doctor arrived after the patient **had died**.

Note : (i) The Past Perfect cannot be used to denote an isolated action in the past. For that, Past Indefinite should be used.

- (ii) Even when the Past Perfect is used by itself in a simple sentence: the action which followed it is implied *e.g.*

He **had already finished** his paper.

8. Past Perfect Continuous Tense

This tense is used : (a) to denote an action had been going on at or before some point of time in the past, *e.g.*

- 1. He **had been living** in this locality for two years before he became my friend.
- 2. She **had been meeting** her boy-friend regularly before her parents came to know about it.

9. Future Indefinite Tense

This tense is used : (a) to denote a single action in the future, *e.g.*

1. I **shall go** to see my friend.
2. He **will** help me.
3. They **will come** here tomorrow.

10. Future Continuous Tense

It denotes an action that will be going on at some time in the future, *e.g.*

1. We **shall be playing** cricket in the evening tomorrow.
2. They **will be discussing** this matter on the morning of the tenth.

11. Future Perfect Tense

It denotes an action that will have been completed at some point of time in the future, *e.g.*

1. We **shall have reached** there by that time.
2. I **shall have written** his essay when you come.

12. Future Perfect Continuous Tense

It denotes an action that will have been going on at or before some point of time in the future, *e.g.*

1. She **will have been dancing** for two hours before we reach there.
2. I **shall have been working** for seven days before my employer comes back.

2 Concord :Agreement of the Verb with Subject

Some useful Hints

1. A **verb** must agree with its Subject in **Number** and **Person**, i.e. when the **Subject** is **Singular**, the **Verb** must be **Singular**; when the **Subject** is **Plural**, the **Verb** must be **Plural**, as,
 - (i) (a) He *plays* cricket.
 - (b) They *play* cricket.
 - (ii) (a) I *am* sad.
 - (b) We *are* sad.
 - (iii) (a) A boy *is* running.
 - (b) Boys *are* running.

The **Verb** must agree with the **Subject Proper**, as,

- (i) The *attitude* of the officers is really friendly.
- (ii) A *list* of girls was prepared.

- (iii) *One* of my friends has gone to U.S.A.
2. If the **Subject** consists of **two or more Singular Nouns** or **Pronouns** joined by '**and**', it takes a Plural Verb.
- (i) *John and Jolly* were two brothers.
- (ii) The poet *and* the dramatist *are* being honoured. (two separate persons)
- (iii) Kolkata, Mumbai, Chennai *and* Delhi *are* the most important cities of India.
- (iv) He *and I* were present.

Exceptions

- (a) If the nouns refer to the same person or thing or express one idea, the Verb is Singular:
- (i) The poet and dramatist *is* being honoured. (*One person only*)
- (ii) My friend, philosopher and guide *was* invited to preside over the function.
- (iii) Rice and Curry *is* his favourite dish.
- (iv) Slow and steady *wins* the race.
- (v) Bread and butter *is* a wholesome food.
- (b) If **Two Singular Subjects** joined by **and** are qualified by **each** or **every**, they take a **Singular verb**.
- (i) *Every* man and *every* woman desires happiness.
- (ii) *Each* hour and *each* minute is important.
3. **Singular Subjects** connected by **or**, **either** **or**, **neither** **nor**, are followed by a **Singular verb**.
- (i) No prize *or* trophy *was* given to him.
- (ii) *Either* Ramesh *or* Ashoka has won the prize.
- (iii) *Neither* Hari *nor* Ramesh has gone to school today.
4. When the **Subjects** connected by **or** or **nor** are of **different Numbers**, the **Plural Subject** should be written last and it is followed by a **Plural Verb**.
- (i) *Either* Ashok *or* his parents *are* to blame.
- (ii) *Neither* he *nor* his friends *have* joined the college.
- (iii) *Neither* the headmaster *nor* the teachers were present there.
5. When the **Subjects** connected by **nor** or **or** are of **different Persons**, the **Verb** agrees in Person with the **Subject nearest to it**.
- (i) *Either* you *or* Lucy *is* responsible for our defeat.
- (ii) *Neither* you *nor* John *seems* to be interested in this pain.
- (iii) *Neither* he *nor* I *have* any money to buy a car.
6. When the Subject consists of **two Nouns or Pronouns** joined by '**with**', the **Verb** agrees with **the first of them**.

- (i) All the students, *with* their teacher, *were* present at the show.
- (ii) He, *with* all his friends, *was* ready to do or die.
7. When **two Subjects** are connected by '**not only but also**', the **Verb** agrees with **the latter Subject**.
- (i) *Not only* the master *but* his servants *also have been* badly wounded.
- (ii) *Not only* the soldiers *but* their captain *also has been* arrested.
8. When the Subject is the formal '**there**' the **Verb** agrees with the real subject that follows it.
- There is no *hope* of his success.
- There were many *difficulties* to be removed.
9. Either, neither, each, everyone, one of the, take a Singular Verb :
- (i) **Neither** of the two books *was* interesting.
- (ii) **Everyone** of these workers *is* an expert.
- (iii) **One of these** students *is* handicapped.
- (iv) **Each** of these two girls *is* intelligent.
- (v) **Either** of these two boys *is* fit for this work.
10. **Nouns** which are **Plural in form** but Singular in meaning should be followed by **Singular Verbs**:
- (i) Mathematics *is* my favourite subject.
- (ii) Politics *is* a dirty game.
- (iii) The wages of sin *is* death.
- (iv) The news *is* too good to be true.
- (v) The United Nations *is* a useful institution.
- (vi) 'Gulliver's Travels' *is* an interesting book.
11. A **Collective Noun** (crew, jury, committee) is followed by **Singular Verb** when the group is thought of as a **Singular unit**. But when individual members of the group are referred to, the **Plural Verb** is used.
- (i) A committee *was* appointed to suggest some reforms.
- (ii) The committee *were* divided on the issue.
- (iii) The jury *was* unanimous in its verdict.
- (iv) The jury *were* divided in their opinions.
12. When the **Subject** of a Verb is a **Relative Pronoun**, the **Verb** agrees in number and Person **with the antecedent of the Relative Pronoun**.
- (i) The *boy, who* always stands first, *is* my son.
- (ii) The *time, which* is lost, *is* lost for ever.

- (iii) I, *who am* your friend, will certainly help you.
 - (iv) This is one of the most interesting *books that have* (not has) ever appeared.
13. When the **Subject** is a **sum of money** considered **as a whole**, the **Singular Verb** is used. If the subject is a sum of money and it refers to the bills or coins **considered seperately**, the **Plural Verb** is used.
- (i) A hundred rupees *is* not a small sum.
 - (ii) A hundred rupees *were* found in his purse.
 - (iii) Five hundred pounds *is* a good price for this tape-recorder.
 - (iv) There *were* fifty rupees in his pocket.
 - (v) There *are* ten silver rupees in my box.

3 Sequence of Tenses

(Some Important Points)

1. A Past Tense in the Main Clause of a sentence having two or more clauses must be followed by a Past Tense in the Subordinate Clause *e.g.*
 - (a) He **passed** the examination because he **had worked** very hard.
 - (b) She **told** me that she **would meet** me in the market.
 - (c) We **laughed** as soon as he **started** singing.
 - (d) He **cried** when she **insulted** him.
 - (e) He **came** soon after you **rang** him up.

Exceptions to this rule

- (a) If the subordinate clause expresses some universal or habitual fact, its verb can remain in the present tense *e.g.*
 1. She **remarked** that honesty is the best policy.
 2. The teacher **said** that the earth revolves round the sun.
 3. He admitted that he **is** a liar.
 - (b) If the subordinate clause is introduced by '**than**' or '**as much as**', its verb can be of any tense that suits the sense *e.g.*
 1. She **favoured** me more than she **favours** anybody else.
 2. She **admired** me as much as she **admired** her husband.
 - (c) If the subordinate clause in an Adjective Clause, its verb may be in any tense that suits the sense *e.g.*
 1. **I liked** the book which you **have** always **criticised**.
 2. They **presented** a play which **will be liked** by all.
2. A Present or Future Tense in the Main Clause can be followed by any tense whatever in the Subordinate Clause *e.g.*

- (a) **I know** she **will not come**.
 (b) You **will soon know** if she **comes** here.

Distinction Between Present Perfect and Past Indefinite

Study the following sentences:

- | | | |
|----|---|-------------------|
| 1. | (a) I <i>saw</i> the Qutab Minar last Sunday. | (Past Indefinite) |
| | (b) I <i>have seen</i> the Qutab Minar. | (Present Perfect) |
| 2. | (a) I <i>wrote</i> to him yesterday. | (Past Indefinite) |
| | (b) I <i>have</i> written to him. | (Present Perfect) |
| 3. | (a) The sun set at 6:15 p.m. yesterday. | (Past Indefinite) |
| | (b) The sun has <i>set</i> . | (Present Perfect) |

A careful study of the above sentences in (a) would reveal that the **Past Indefinite** Tense is used when a **definite time in the past** is given or implied. In sentences (b) the **Present Perfect** has been used because no **definite point of time** has been mentioned. In these sentences, **we** are interested only in the completion of the action as we know it now.

Generally, the Past Indefinite carries expressions like *last night, yesterday, last Monday, in the evening, last year, at 5 p.m.*, etc. with it.

The Present Perfect carries expressions like *so far, by now, up to now, recently, lately, just now*, etc. with it.

Distinction between Present Continuous and Present Indefinite (with regard to the use of time expressions)

Study the following sentences:

- | | | |
|----|--|----------------------|
| 1. | (a) I play cricket almost every day . | (Present Indefinite) |
| | (b) I am playing cricket now . | (Present Continuous) |
| 2. | (a) He drinks every evening . | (Present Indefinite) |
| | (b) He is drinking now . | (Present Continuous) |
| 3. | (a) It rains in August every year . | (Present Indefinite) |
| | (b) It is raining at the moment . | (Present Continuous) |

From the above examples, it is quite clear that the **Present Continuous** Tense is used to represent an action **that is going on at the time of speaking** while the **Present Indefinite** is used to represent any **habitual action or general or universal truth**.

Time expressions like *generally, always, after, frequently, twice a day, once a year, usually, sometimes, every day, every Sunday, every year*, in August etc. are usually used with the **Present Indefinite Tense**.

Time expressions like *now*, *at the moment*, *at present*, etc. are generally used with the **Present Continuous Tense**.

Exercises for Practice

Exercise 1

Correct the Tense in the following sentences :

- (a)
1. They have come yesterday.
 2. I have bought this house last year.
 3. I am the person who have saved your life.
 4. I shall call you when the lunch will be ready.
 5. Dinesh will come if you will invite him.
 6. I had been to Delhi recently.
 7. She is one of those persons who never tells a lie.
 8. She is working in the office for two years.
 9. I had gone to the club last night.
 10. I have written to him yesterday.
- (b)
1. I hoped that my friend will help me.
 2. Take care that you will not be cheated.
 3. I know them for the last four years.
 4. The patient died before the doctor arrived.
 5. Newton has discovered the Law of Gravitation.
 6. I am studying hard for the last three weeks.
 7. He is suffering from fever since Monday.
 8. I had visited Shimla last summer.
 9. I am sorry I did not write that letter yet.
 10. His younger sister is died.

Exercise 2

Put the correct Verb in the blanks :

- | | | |
|---|----------------------------|---------------|
| 1. The tallest of these boys | next door to me. | (live, lives) |
| 2. Slow and steady | the race. | (win, wins) |
| 3. Neither Ashok nor Prem | any right to the property. | (has, have) |
| 4. Neither the captain nor the soldiers | been arrested. | (has, have) |
| 5. Neither he nor I | money to spare for his. | (has, have) |
| 6. You, as well as he, | innocent. | (is, are) |

7. None but the brave the fair. (deserve, deserves)
8. The United States a prosperous country. (is, are)
9. The committee divided in their opinion. (was, were)
10. I, who your friend, will stand by you. (is, am, are)

Exercise 3

Put the correct Verb in the blanks :

1. All the players in my team done well. (has, have)
2. Bread and butter what they want. (is, are)
3. Either Sushil or Rakesh done this mischief. (has, have)
4. Neither he nor his servants honest. (was, were)
5. Neither you nor Sham to be capable of doing this. (appear, appears)
6. Not only the workman but the supervisor also been dismissed. (has, have)
7. Each day and each hour its own importance. (has, have)
8. The news of the flood caused great anxiety. (has, have)
9. The jury divided in their opinion. (was, were)
10. This is one of the best novels that been published this year. (has, have)

Exercise 4

Put the correct Verb in the blanks :

1. The cost of all types of pens gone up. (has, have)
2. Time and tide for none. (wait, waits)
3. Either you or he mistaken. (is, are)
4. Either Rajinder or his parents responsible for this. (was, were)
5. Neither you nor I lucky. (am, are)
6. He, as well as you, to blame. (is, are)
7. None of the ships rescued from the storm. (was, were)
8. The Arabian Nights interesting stories. (contain, contains)
9. The crew did best to save the ship. (its, their)
10. This is one of the most difficult lessons that been taught. (has, have)

Exercise 5

Put the correct Verb in the blanks :

1. The toys that were bought by my son really useful. (is, are)

2. Oil and water mix. (does not, do not)
3. Neither the judge nor the witnesses him. (believe, believes)
4. Neither the Principal nor the lecturers present at the meeting. (was, were)
5. Either he or I wrong. (am, are)
6. The workmen, with their leaders, been arrested. (have, has)
7. One of my friends the owner of this factory. (is, are)
8. Good crockery expensive. (is, are)
9. The jury divided on the issue. (was, were)
10. I am one who always stood for justice. (has, have)

Exercise 6

Put the correct Verb in the blanks :

1. He regurally. (work, works)
2. Tobacco and alcohol injurious to health. (is, are)
3. Either the officer or the assistants responsible for this error. (is, are)
4. Me or his friends to blame. (was, were)
5. Neither my brother nor I ever been to Mumbai. (has, have)
6. The gallery, with its beautiful pictures, a great attraction. (is, are)
7. Either of these two proposals acceptable to me. (is, are)
8. The West Indies a land of great cricketers. (is, are)
9. The Assembly in session. (is, are)
10. He is one of those leaders who always ready to do or die. (is, are)